

there is nothing quite so disquieting as constant reassurance “for your comfort and safety.”

Yet the figures are unequivocal. Although accident statistics fluctuate from year to year, flying on a commercial airliner always emerges as by far the safest way of traveling long distances. In 1996, for example, a relatively bad year for aviation deaths, a total of 1,187 people were killed on commercial jet flights worldwide. This compares with over 40,000 people killed that year in road accidents in the United States alone, and worldwide probably a quarter of a million road-accident deaths. Flying is far from being equally safe in different parts of the world: in a typical year, the United States might have one flight fatality for every two million passenger-hours flown, while Africa might have 13 fatalities per

million flight hours. But even in Africa, you are more likely to be killed or injured driving to and from the airport than on board the airplane. The risk of a fatal accident each time you board an airliner has been calculated at roughly three in a million. This means that if an otherwise immortal individual made a flight every day, he or she could expect, on average, to survive for over 900 years before dying in an air accident. (Flying in a private aircraft carries a quite different risk—it is almost 50 times more dangerous than flying in a commercial jet.)

Progress on safety has been the necessary condition for the development of mass air travel. In the early 1930s, there was a fatality for every 4.8 million passenger-miles flown in the United States. In a single, admittedly exceptional, period

in the winter of 1936–37, there were five fatal air crashes in the US in 28 days. Translated into the contemporary world of widebody jets, a 1930s-style accident rate would have produced a totally unacceptable mass of fatalities. By the 1980s, American airlines flying major routes had reduced the death rate to around one for every 300 million passenger-miles. Even so, recent decades set all the records for air disasters, because of the large numbers of passengers on a single flight. The worst year for air-accident fatalities worldwide was 1985, with 2,129 people killed—although 1,105 of the victims died in just three incidents. In 2005, a worse than average year for aviation in recent times, there were 1,050 deaths worldwide. To put this in perspective, there were by then some 1.2 billion passengers being carried

LOCKERBIE DISASTER

A terrorist bomb was responsible for the destruction of the Pan Am Boeing 747 that exploded above the small Scottish town of Lockerbie in December 1988. Despite constant efforts to upgrade security at airports, it remains extremely difficult to prevent the smuggling of bombs or weapons on to airliners.

